



Moscow to host U.S. team in peace talks

Putin signals openness to proposal modified in negotiations with Kyiv

BY MARY ILYUSHINA

Russia is expecting a U.S. delegation in Moscow next week, led by special envoy Steve Witkoff, to discuss the U.S. proposal for a peace deal that President Vladimir Putin called a “basis for future agreements.”

His comment Thursday suggested a degree of openness to President Donald Trump’s latest attempt to resolve the Russia-Ukraine conflict. The original 28-point plan was modified in U.S.-Ukrainian negotiations in Geneva last weekend to make it more palatable to Kyiv.

“In general, we agree that this could form the basis for future agreements, but it would be rude of me to talk about any final versions now, since there are none. Some things are fundamental in nature, and in general we see that the American side is taking into account our position, which was discussed before Anchorage and after Alaska,” Putin said at a security summit in Kyrgyzstan.

He said in a news conference that “as we have previously agreed, the meeting is being offered by the U.S. side in Moscow next week.” He said he expected Witkoff to be there.

Putin’s statement comes more than a week after the full 28-point plan was leaked to the news media, unsettling Kyiv and several European governments, which view parts of the document as overly favorable to Moscow. Subsequent counterproposals from European leaders and Ukraine

SEE RUSSIA ON A10

Suspect in D.C. ambush had worked with CIA



MARVIN JOSEPH/THE WASHINGTON POST

National Guard troops salute Thursday night near the Dwight D. Eisenhower Memorial as the body of Sarah Beckstrom is transported.

One Guard victim dies as other fights for his life

BY CASEY PARKS, LIZ SKALKA, PRAVEENA SOMASUNDARAM AND TARA COPP

Two years ago, Sarah Beckstrom’s life was just getting started. She was selling discount tickets to her senior prom. Later, she posted about canning peppers and making her own butter. And last year, her mother posted a new photograph of Beckstrom holding a gun and wearing camouflage. The teenager had joined the Army National Guard in June

West Virginia woman, 20, had joined military right out of high school

2023, the same month she graduated high school.

“My baby girl,” her father, Gary, commented under the photo in February 2024. Two weeks later, Gary posted a photograph of Beckstrom in her dress greens with a military police emblem

pinned above her name. “My baby is a graduate now,” he wrote.

In mid-August, Beckstrom, 20, went with the Guard to D.C. as part of President Donald Trump’s plan to use the Guard to counter crime in the city. Beckstrom was deputized this week to maintain her status to conduct those security patrols, according to the National Guard’s Joint Task Force-D.C.

On Wednesday, less than 24 hours later, Spec. Beckstrom and another Guard member, Staff Sgt. Andrew Wolfe, were on patrol

near 17th and I streets in Northwest Washington when a lone gunman opened fire on them with a Smith & Wesson .357-caliber revolver, officials said. Officials have described the attack as “brazen and targeted.”

On Thursday night, Trump announced that Beckstrom had died with her parents at her side. “Incredible person. Outstanding in every single way,” he said during a video call with service members from Mar-a-Lago.

Wolfe remained in critical condition. SEE VICTIMS ON A12

AFGHAN WAS PART OF U.S. ‘ZERO UNITS’

Daytime shooting sparks a sweeping investigation

BY JOSHUA PARTLOW, DANA HEDGPETH, NICOLE ASBURY AND WARREN P. STROBEL

An Afghan national who previously worked with the CIA will face multiple criminal charges after federal authorities said he drove across the country and shot two National Guard members — one fatally — in an ambush Wednesday afternoon near the White House.

The shooting, which came months into the Guard’s deployment in the District at President Donald Trump’s behest, has sparked an intense, international investigation into the motive of the alleged gunman, 29-year-old Rahmanullah Lakanwal of Bellingham, Washington, who came to the United States in September 2021 after working for a CIA-organized counterterrorism squad.

Lakanwal, who was detained moments after the shooting, was part of one of the U.S. government’s “Zero Units” that were involved in combat missions to seize or kill suspected terrorists, according to several people familiar with the matter, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to publicly discuss details of the investigation.

Jeanine Pirro, U.S. attorney for D.C., said at a news conference Thursday that Lakanwal came to the nation’s capital to commit what officials called a “targeted attack,” shooting two West Virginia National Guard members — Sarah Beckstrom, 20, and Andrew Wolfe, 24.

In a call with service members Thursday night, Trump said Beckstrom had died after being “savagely” attacked. Wolfe, he said, was still fighting for his life.

SEE SHOOTING ON A12

In first trip abroad, Leo pushes for unity

Papal visit to Turkey harks back to legacy of church’s internal dispute

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA

ANKARA, TURKEY — Seeking to unify a recently decriminalized faith, Roman emperor Constantine the Great called a summit of early Christians in the ancient Anatolian city of Nicaea. The then-nascent religion’s theologians were clashing, over no issue more than the origins of Jesus Christ.

On his first international trip as pontiff, Pope Leo XIV arrived Thursday in Turkey — site of the ancient summit — to commemorate the 1,700th anniversary of the Council of Nicaea. On Friday, joined by Eastern Orthodox leaders, diplomats and other faith leaders, he will hark back to an era before the splintering of Christianity at a prayer service near the submerged archaeological site of the Basilica of St. Neophytos in Iznik, formerly Nicaea.

But he will also be implicitly recognizing a legacy of internal

SEE POPE ON A8



DANA HEDGPETH/THE WASHINGTON POST

Laura McCarty, with St. Mary’s College of Maryland, works at Fones Cliffs in Virginia.

Dig reveals site of Indian villages

Artifacts link Virginia area to tribe that 17th-century explorer wrote about

BY DANA HEDGPETH

Centuries-old documents told of Native American settlements in the Fones Cliffs area of the Rappahannock River in Virginia’s Northern Neck.

In the 1600s, English explorer John Smith wrote of how he and his men were attacked by Native Americans along the river. A document from the 1660s

detailed how the Rappahannock Tribe was promised 30 blankets in exchange for more than 25,000 acres of its land.

But the exact location of these towns had never been pinpointed until now.

Archaeologists cross-referenced historic maps, documents and deeds with oral histories from Rappahannock tribal members. Then last fall,

in the woods of Richmond County on areas near the bluffs, they started digging.

For months, the crew from St. Mary’s College of Maryland surveyed the land to try to find the early settlements but found nothing that could be linked to Smith’s foray. Then this summer, they came upon items on land the Rappahannock Tribe

SEE VILLAGES ON A6

Feelings on economy are sinking — but not equally

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

It’s no secret that Americans are frustrated by the economy: Consumer sentiment has fallen for four straight months to one of its lowest levels on record, according to a closely watched metric from the University of Michigan.

In surveys, people report feeling exasperated by high prices and slowing incomes. The job market is weakening, and the stock market has been inching down from last month’s record highs. A measure by the Conference Board released Tuesday

showed a sharp decline in consumer confidence in November.

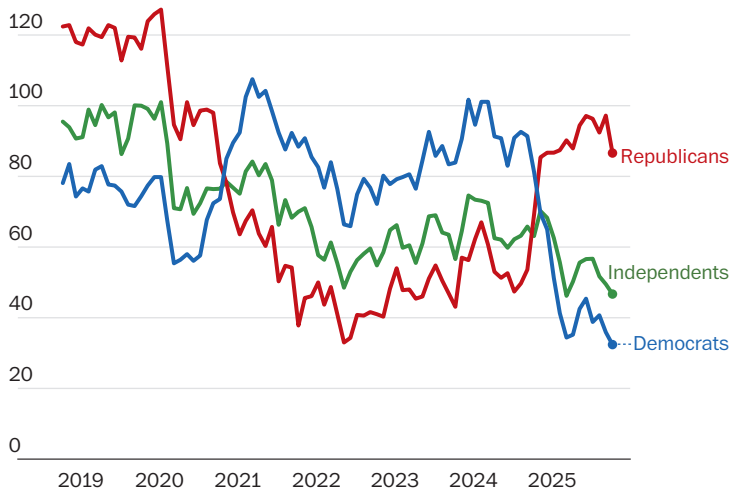
“Consumer economic sentiment is suffering,” said Elizabeth Renter, senior economist at NerdWallet. “People are concerned about affordability, the labor market and business conditions.”

But not everyone is equally upset. A closer look at the data shows considerable variance based on factors such as a person’s age, income and political leaning. Some people are even feeling better about their finances now than they were a few months ago.

SEE CONSUMERS ON A13

Republicans are most optimistic about the economy

Consumer sentiment index, by political party



November data is preliminary

Source: University of Michigan surveys of consumers ABHA BHATTARAI / THE WASHINGTON POST

IN THE NEWS

Hong Kong blaze The death toll from this week’s huge fire at a high-rise apartment complex grew to 83, and more than 270 people were missing. A14

Black Friday Higher prices, not more buying, are expected to drive most spending growth among inflation-fatigued consumers. A18

THE NATION A Florida jeweler restored intricate religious relics tarnished during Hurricane Ian. A3
A tortoise that endured two world wars and the terms of over 20 presidents dies at 141. A4

THE WORLD President Trump’s fluid diplomacy drives a new Ukraine peace push — and fresh turmoil. A10
If forced to flee, Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro may find refuge in Turkey. A15

THE ECONOMY Foreign visitors to some U.S. national parks will soon face “America-first” upcharges for access. A7
The holidays are a great time to score deals on a new television. Let us help you unscramble the jargon and dodge the duds. A18

STYLE “Left-Handed Girl” is a stunner of a Taiwanese film about a young girl who engages in some incredibly cute petty theft. B1

SPORTS The Packers held off the Lions on another Thanksgiving filled with NFL action. B7

THE REGION The death of Zoey Rose Marie Harrison, 3, has led to a law that will reform police pursuit rules in Pr. George’s. B13

WEEKEND From “Nutcrackers” to concerts to parades, check out some of the D.C. area’s best ways to celebrate the season.

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